Moon Song

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31283225.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), (Okay she's implied more than anything it will make sense when you get there), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), albeit briefly, George (She-Ra), Lance (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Inspired by Tangled (2010), Friends to Lovers, I am Glimbow Trash, I Wrote This Instead of Sleeping, this got me through finals week, the title is a Pheobe Bridgers song that I had on repeat for days

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by somebodysmuse

Summary

Once a year, for the honor of Bright Moon's lost princess, the sky turns pink and purple, and for only a few moments, there are stars again. Glimmer has watched the changing sky from the window of her tower for 18 years, trying to be content by the presence of her distant mother and the assurance that she is safe and hidden away.

Then, one day, a very sweet archer finds her tower and changes everything.

(Alternate Summary: Glimbow Tangled AU.)

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Prologue

Even though his siblings insist that it isn't possible, Bow swears that he remembers the Princess's first birthday. He knows that he was only a few months short of two years old at the time, but he remembers sitting on his oldest brother's shoulders so he could see King Micah and Queen Angella standing on the balcony of their palace, holding the baby princess in their arms. He remembers them each raising on arm to the sky and casting a spell, and turning the entire sky a thousand shades of pink and purple, and for the first time in his life, he remembers stars glittering in the sky. This was, as his dads explained to him later, for the princess's namesake. She was named Glimmer. He remembers looking up at the sky and thinking it was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen in his life.

And he remembers, a few weeks later, when the palace guards came into their house and started turning over tables and rummaging through their cupboards. He remembers them pulling books off of their shelves, ruining his dads' perfect organization system. He remembers them pushing past his dads, telling them that their protests weren't of consequence; the princess was missing, had been taken from her crib in the middle of the night, and everyone, even scholars who had never broken a single law or made any trouble whatsoever, scholars who had assisted the king and queen and worked closely alongside them both for years, was a suspect. Even their children. He remembers his dads packing up their things and moving Bow and all twelve of his siblings to a house in the Whispering Woods, talking about how they wouldn't be treated like criminals in their own kingdom, especially after everything they had done for the royal family.

And he remembers the next year, standing beside the apple tree that grew in the front lawn of his new house, when the sky turned

colors again, and the stars sparkled.

He remembers asking his dads if they thought the princess would ever come home. They don't answer him, but they do hold him tighter and watch the sky.

oOo

Not a trace.

That was the phrase that Queen Angella kept using when discussing the disappearance of her daughter. She and her husband ordered the palace guards to search every corner of the kingdom and beyond to look for her.

At the end of three days, the Captain of the Guard went to the king and queen, sitting in foyer together.

"Your Highness," he said. "I- I'm sorry, but- but she's not in the village."

Queen Angella covered her face and took a deep breath.

"Is it possible that someone from the Horde took her?" He asked. "Maybe to use as a ransom?"

“It’s been three days,” King Micah said. “I’m sure they would have sent us their terms by now.”

“Then- well, is there anyone who we should be looking for other than the princess?” He asked. “Someone who- someone who might want to harm her? Any suspects?”

The king and queen shared a glance.

“The magician who taught me magic,” The king said after a moment. “She…she paid us a visit about two months after Glimmer was born.”

“The one who lost all of her magic with that experiment?” The Captain asked.

“Not all of her magic,” Angella said, uncovering her face. “But most of it. She left the kingdom for years before coming back, and…and she told us that she was dying, and she had spent the last years trying to find a way to stop it. With what little magic she had left, she had created two pendants, one that could harness another’s magic and transfer it to her, and keep her alive in the process.”

“Could it?” The captain asked.

The queen nodded her head. “She put hers on a chain and put it around her neck and put the other just above Glimmer’s heart, and she…well, it was like nothing had changed. She had her power again.”

“Extraordinary magic, to be sure,” The king said bitterly.

“Couldn’t she have used someone else? Surely the princess isn’t the only child with magic.”

“She said that we owed her Glimmer’s power,” The queen said, shaking her head. Her eyes were beginning to full with tears. “Because it was our fault that she was dying. She wanted Glimmer and Glimmer alone.”

The queen pressed her lips together, trying to compose herself. Micah placed his hand on her arm, tears streaming down his face.

“But Glimmer wouldn’t have been able to use her own magic- it would have been siphoned to keep her alive. And she was- she was already so powerful, so full of magic- she was teleporting to and from her crib when she was just a few weeks old. We told her ‘no,’ and she disappeared. For months, we didn’t see her, we didn’t hear from her- we could only assume that she had found someone else or had…or had passed away. Then someone took Glimmer…someone took our child…” The queen shook her head. “And we haven’t found her since. And Light Spinner is gone- disappeared without a trace.”

The king wrapped his arms around his wife's shoulders, the fact that they weren't alone be damned- his wife was in tears and his heart was broken. The Captain of the guard assured both of them that they wouldn't rest until the princess was found before finally leaving them alone.

"What are we going to do?" Angella asked, burying her face in her husband's chest. "How can we bring her back?"

Micah sighed and glanced out the window. Night had fallen, and not a single star sparkled against the endless sky.

"We'll cast her a spell," He said. "We'll cast a spell on the entire sky so she can see it and know that we're still looking."

Angella nodded her head and wept. Micah held her tighter and kept looking at the sky.

oOo

Glimmer remembers being four years old when her Mother finally answered one of her questions.

Of course, it wasn't the first question she ever asked, that honor belonged to "Why can't I take off my necklace?"

It wasn’t that she didn’t like it, necessarily, and she didn’t mind that it matched the same one that her Mother wore, but when she tried to take it off one day, she remembers being yelled at. She remembers crying.

“What happens if I take my necklace off?”

“Don’t worry about that,” She snapped. “Don’t you dare take it off ever again.”

A few weeks later, she found out why she wasn’t allowed to go outside. She remembers asking why they live in a tower, and why she insists on casting an invisibility charm on it every time she leaves.

She remembers sitting on her lap one Summer night when all of a sudden, the sky turned the most beautiful shades of purple and pink that she’s ever seen, and the stars shone brighter, like they were glittering on purpose.

“Look at how pretty it is!” She remembers saying excitedly, pointing at the window.

“It certainly is,” Mother answered. Glimmer has never seen her mother's face- only the always-present mask she wears, but she knows how to detect her mood from her voice, even at only four. She knows that she is about to teach her something.

“Why does it look like that? Does it do this every night?”

“No, my sweet, only on the late princess’s birthday, who I named you after. She was killed not long before you were born.”

“The princess died?” Glimmer asked, her eyes growing wide.

“Yes, it was terribly sad,” She sighed. “The poor king and queen have never quite recovered. I just hope that throwing magic at the sky makes them feel better. That’s why we’re up here, you know.”

“Because the princess died?”

“Not quite- but because someone was cruel enough to kill an innocent little princess. And everything with the war- do you remember what I told you about the Horde? And about the Rebellion?”

Glimmer nodded her head.

“I won’t expose you to so much cruelty,” she said. “And if no one finds you, no one can hurt you. Do you understand?”

Glimmer nodded her head and continued to watch the sky.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer put her washcloth down, placed the last plate in the cupboard, and frowned. It was barely the afternoon and she had already finished her chores- the tower was clean, the dishes were done, and she still had hours of time to fill.

She glanced up at the bookshelves, full of books that she had already read. Maybe when her mother came back, she could ask for more books.

Her frown deepened- she wasn't sure when her mother was coming back. It had been almost four days without her. Normally, Glimmer didn't mind being alone- it wasn't like she had much choice, but after three days of painting and reading and cooking and writing, it was easy to feel restless.

She sighed and walked to the living room. There was a paintbrush atop one of the tables. She picked it up and twirled it between her fingers.

I like it here, she reminded herself. And she did; her tower was well-decorated, with comfortable furniture and lots of books, and after she had started painting the walls (hence the paintbrush) with flowers and trees, the room became infinitely more colorful, even in the darkness of night.

"I like it here," She said aloud. After everything that she had heard about the war, about how someone had literally killed a baby just because of who her parents were- she could content staying inside. She could look out the window and feel the soft, Spring breezes and ignore the feeling that her life was slipping away. She had done so for 18 long years.

Then something on the windowsill caught her eye- and her heart skipped a beat just before everything changed.

oOo

Bow was starting to wonder whether or not all this sneaking around was worth it. He hated lying to his dads, he hated having to find places around the woods to hide his bow and arrows, and he especially hated having to find secret places around the Whispering Woods that were far enough away from his house that his dads wouldn't find him practicing, but not so far that he would get lost.

"I'm not lost," He said out loud. "I am not lost. I am just…in a part of the Woods that I've never been in before. And it's nice."

He supposed that it was nice; the tree that he had passed a little while ago had been one of the biggest he had ever seen, and there was a very pretty brook just there…

Wait. Did that…

"Huh," he said softly.

He must have been in a part of the Woods he had never been in before, because he was sure he would have remembered a tower- one that appeared to have daisies growing up its sides-

But it seemed like it had only just…materialized in front of him. He walked around to the other side- there was a rope hanging from the window. It looked like it had been there for a long time. Was this abandoned?

If it's abandoned, he thought, *you'd have a place to practice. And a place to store all of your equipment.*

"There's only one way to find out," He said, and took the rope in his hands, grateful for the Summer that he and his siblings spent learning how to climb ropes. Granted, this tower was much taller than anything he and his siblings climbed, he was very nearly panting by the time he reached the window and pulled himself up.

When he stumbled inside, he heard a gasp. Raising his head, he saw a girl- probably around his age, maybe even younger- standing inside, her purple eyes wider than dinner plates. She was holding a paintbrush.

“Oh,” He said. “Hi, how-“

“Stay right where you are!” She said. “Don’t take another step!”

Bow, stunned into silence, did as he was told. “Uh, is everything-“

“Don’t come any closer!” She cried, brandishing her paintbrush like it was a sword.

“Alright, alright!” Bow said, raising his hands. “I’m so sorry, I didn’t mean to startle-“

“Put your weapon down!” She demanded. “Slowly!”

Bow reached behind him and removed his quiver, placing them beside his fallen bow.

“How did you find me?” She asked as he rose. “Who else knows where I am?”

“I was just looking for a place to practice, and no one else knows! I promise!” He said. The girl took a step closer to him.

“What’s your name?” She asked, her brow still furrowed.

“Bow. What’s-“

“I am the one asking the questions!” She snapped. Bow was silent. “Why are you here?”

“Because I- I don’t know,” He sighed. “I don’t know, I was just- I was just curious-“

“You can’t break into people’s houses just because you’re curious!”

“I know, but I thought it was some kind of a ruin, and my dads are really about that kind of thing, and I thought that if I climbed the tower, I could find something and I would have an excuse for being out of the house all day that didn’t involve me telling them that I’m teaching myself archery, and-“

“Wait, you found the tower?” She asked. “It’s supposed to be invisible!”

“Is it?” He asked.

“She casts a charm every time she leaves- you could really just- just see it?”

Bow nodded his head. Her eyes widened even more.

"Oh, no…" She said, finally lowering her paintbrush and running to the windowsill. "Darn it, I forgot to…" She grabbed the rope that Bow had used to climb the tower and yanked it inside. "You can still see the tower, oh…"

"I'm sorry, I'm intruding, I'll leave-"

"No!" She cried. For the first time, she didn't sound angry- she sounded almost scared. "Just- you really don't want anything to do with me?"

"I won't hurt you," He said honestly. "I promise, I will never do anything to harm you. Unless you try to stab me with that paintbrush, then I might have to defend myself."

Her lip twitched, like she wanted to smile, but her features quickly fell back into a look of concern.

"What's wrong?" He asked.

"The invisibility charm," She said, walking to the window. "It means that the tower is visible. People can find me."

“Would that be so bad?”

“People who might try to hurt me can find me,” She said. “That’s what she says, that…”

He looked down and saw that her hands were trembling.

“Hey,” He said softly. “It’s okay. I promise, no one’s going to-“

“You don’t know that!” She snapped. Bow fell silent and looked back down at her hands. She had stubby fingers, and it looked like she had been biting her nails.

“I have a proposition for you,” She said after a moment, her voice stronger and more composed.

“Alright,” He said.

“If you stand guard at the window until the sun sets, I am willing to offer you-“ She reached to one of the shelves and grabbed a strangely-shaped piece of pottery. “This. You can tell your dads that you found it in the woods and wanted to look for more.”

“Technically I did find it in the woods,” He supposed. “Won’t you miss it, though?”

“I do a lot of pottery,” She said, shrugging her shoulders. “I won’t miss one cup.”

“This is a cup?”

“Yes,” She said, like it was obvious. “It has a handle and you can drink out of it.”

Bow found himself cracking a small smile. “Alright, then. You’ve got yourself a deal.”

“Excellent,” She said, holding out her hand. It wasn’t trembling anymore. He shook it.

“Am I allowed to know your name?” He asked. “Or is that too personal for our business venture?”

This time, she was the one that smiled at him. “I’m Glimmer.”

“It’s nice to meet you,” He said.

“You too,” She said smoothly, pulling her hand out of his. He hadn’t realized that he was still holding on.

“Get to work,” She said smoothly, leaving him at the window.

oOo

What did people talk about?

Glimmer stole another glance at her visitor, sitting on her windowsill. What was she supposed to ask him about? Was it weird that she wasn’t talking? It was almost sundown, and she hadn’t found a single thing to say to him since he arrived that afternoon.

This is what living in a tower for eighteen years will do to you, she griped internally.

Then she reminded herself, as she often had in her life, why she was here. It was for her protection, she was safer here. And it wasn’t like Mother would put her there for any reason other than her own good.

And I trust her, she reminded herself as she walked to the windowsill.

“Would you like some tea?” She asked, trying to make it seem like she talked to people all the time, like she wasn’t some shut-in who

had no manners and no social skills.

"That'd be great, thanks," He said, and smiled. He had a nice smile, all dimples and perfect white teeth. She smiled back.

"Do you take yours with sugar or honey?" She asked, grabbing two more cups from the cupboard.

"Honey, please," He said.

"Are you making a daisy chain?" She asked a few moments later when she came back to the window, holding to cups of hot tea.

Bow looked up from the flower he was holding.

"Yes. Well, I guess it's technically a flower crown."

She wanted to tell him that he wasn't supposed to be making flower crowns, that he was supposed to be standing guard to make sure no one tried to harm her- but she couldn't bring herself to do it. She could barely bring herself to feel frightened by his presence.

After all, he had promised that he wouldn't let anything happen to her. She had a feeling that it was a promise he would keep.

“It’s lovely,” she said, handing him his tea. She wondered, for a moment, if she should walk away. She had given him his tea, and he probably didn’t want to talk to her-

“I have a proposition for you,” Bow said, pulling her out of her thoughts.

“Alright,” She said. “We need to start writing these down, though. We could get confused.”

“It’s simple enough,” He said. “I want to ask you three questions.”

She raised her eyebrows. “Why?”

“Because believe it or not, I don’t meet a lot of people who live in towers in the woods, and I’m curious.”

“Didn’t we discuss your curiosity already?”

He shrugged. “You don’t have to anything if it’s too personal-“

“No,” She said, surprised at how badly she wanted to answer Bow’s questions. When was the last time anyone had ever asked her about herself? “Just- well, what’s in it for me.”

Bow furrowed his brow. “What do you want?”

“Can I ask you three questions, too?” She asked.

“Easy,” He answered, grinning. “Come on, sit with me.”

Glimmer sat beside him on the windowsill, warmed by the setting sun and her cooling tea in her hands.

“Can I go first?” He asked.

“Be my guest.”

“Do you live here alone?”

She shook her head. “No, I live with my mother. Well, she lived here when I was younger. When I turned twelve, she kind of started coming and going every couple of days.”

“She leaves you here by yourself?”

“She’s busy- she makes these healing potions and goes to sell them, and like I said, the tower is invisible most of the time.”

“So why isn’t it now?” Bow asked.

“Maybe because she’s been gone for almost four days,” Glimmer said. “Most of the time, she’s back within three- I guess it’s not a very long-lasting charm.”

“So she has magic?”

Glimmer nodded her head. “Not very much, I don’t think- she’s never shown me anything particularly grand.”

Bow nodded his head.

“Alright, you’ve asked two, now it’s my turn.”

“No, I only asked the one,” He corrected her.

“No, you asked if I live alone, and if Mother has magic.”

“Ah, shoot,” He said, frowning. “I didn’t even realize.”

“Rookie mistake,” She chastised gently. “My turn.”

“Go on.”

“What do your parents do?” She asked.

“They’re historians,” He said. “They used to work for the king and queen before- well, it’s kind of a long story,” He said. “But we live in a house in the Whispering Woods- we’re pretty tucked away, too. They like their privacy, and when you’re raising thirteen kids, it’s nice to have the enough space for them to play outside.”

“Thirteen children?” Glimmer asked, her eyes widening. “There are thirteen of you?”

“Well, it’s just me, now.” He said. “Everyone else has scattered to the wind- most of them went to study at universities, and I think one of my sisters teaches music at some school- but still, all intellectuals.”

“Is that what you want to do?”

“Well-“ He looked uneasy. “It’s kind of- well-“

“I’m sorry,” she said. “I didn’t mean to pry, I-“

“Hey, don’t go,” He said, seeing that she was getting ready to stand. She stopped moving and sat back down. “You aren’t prying at all. They just- well, they want me to take over the library and carry on the whole historian legacy, you know?”

“And you want to do something else?”

He nodded his head. “I want to go to Bright Moon- that’s why I’ve been learning archery- and I want to join the Rebellion.”

“That’s brave of you,” She said. “Why- never mind.”

“No, not never mind. What’s up?”

“I’ve already asked my three,” She said glumly. “I should have saved at least one of them.”

“Well,” Bow said. “Here’s an idea. We could try not counting.”

“I like that idea,” Glimmer said brightly.

“I do too,” He said. “So, what were you going to ask.”

“I was just wondering, why wouldn’t your dads want you to help Queen Angella? It seems like an awfully noble thing to do.”

“My Dads used to work for the King and Queen pretty closely, but when the princess went missing, they didn’t like how they were being treated, like they were criminals. That’s when they quit and moved us to the Woods. I don’t think they’d want me to work with the royal family again.”

Glimmer nodded her head. “I’m sorry,” She said.

“Don’t be,” He said, shaking his head. “It’s- I’ll find a way to tell them someday.”

She nodded her head again and watched him play with the daisies in his lap.

“Wait,” She said after a moment. “You said that Queen Angella’s daughter was kidnapped?”

Bow nodded his head. “Yeah, when she was just a year old.”

“But- but I thought the princess died,” Glimmer said. “That’s what my mother told me.”

“No, she was kidnapped, just after her first birthday.”

“But the princess was killed,” Glimmer said. “That’s what my mother said.”

“Maybe she’s mistaken,” Bow said.

“That’s never happened before,” Glimmer said. “She’s normally so knowledgeable. And…no, she wouldn’t- she wouldn’t have lied to me…”

Bow was silent, trying to remain neutral. After all, he had never met Glimmer’s mother, but after hearing that she left her alone for days at a time without company, and now knowing that she might have lied to her, it was hard for him to like her very much.

“No, she wouldn’t have, and I trust her,” Glimmer said, like she was convincing herself and not him. Bow was silent for a moment.

“You know, if you want,” He said. “I can take you to see the house sometime. You can meet my dads, see the library…”

Glimmer looked down at her lap. She had never, not once, left her tower. And she knew- she just knew- that Bow wouldn’t let any

harm come to her if she did leave. But she also knew that she could never explain that to her Mother. She wouldn't have understood, and Glimmer didn't want to make her angry.

"I don't- I don't think that would be a good idea," She said, tucking a strand of dark, wavy hair behind her ear.

Bow nodded his head. "Alright, no worries, then. If you aren't comfortable, then it's no big deal."

She smiled. "You're very sweet, you know."

"Ah, shucks," He said. "You'll make me blush."

She laughed. "That's my revenge for making me answer more than three questions."

"It's a small price to pay. I like talking to you," He said.

"I like talking to you, too," She realized aloud. He looked at her and smiled. She felt a warm blush creeping on her cheeks and turned away.

"It's almost dark," She said. "I guess- well, I guess you're relieved of your duties."

Bow stood. “It was an honor serving you, my lady.”

Glimmer laughed. “You were well-compensated, don’t forget that.”

He gathered his bow and arrows, and Glimmer felt her heart sinking. She had just had the best conversation of her life, and she had learned so much about Bow- but she still felt like she didn’t know him at all. She wanted to know him.

“Bow?” She asked softly. “Will I see you again?”

He looked at her for a moment, studying her. Her eyes were the strangest shade of violet he had ever seen, like a perfect cross between purple and pink.

“Of course,” He said. “I’ll be back tomorrow, if you want.”

Her heart soared and she felt herself smile. “Thank you, Bow. Really.”

“Don’t mention it,” He said. “Will you be alright for tonight? Since- you know, the charm isn’t working?”

"I'll be fine," She said bravely, though she was dreading spending the night alone with her tower visible.

If you hadn't been visible, Bow wouldn't have found you, she realized.

"Alright," He said.

"And- please, just- don't tell anyone I'm here," Glimmer said. "Just because-"

"I understand," He said. "Don't worry."

"And- look, if you come back tomorrow and my Mother is back- just…look, I don't want to be rude, but- but just come back the next day, alright?"

Bow's brow furrowed again, but he nodded his head.

"Alright," He said. "What if- well, what if the tower is invisible again?"

"Oh, right," She said. "Alright, do you remember how you found it?"

"Yeah, there was a giant tree, then a stream, and then this weird curtain of leaves…"

“Okay,” She said. “It’s an easy fix- once you come back, just yell for me. Once I lower this,” She took the ribbon in her hands. “It will be visible to you, and you are welcome to climb on up.”

“That’s fascinating,” He said. “So the rope is what triggers the invisibility charm?”

“It’s supposed to,” She said. “I left it on the window overnight and it must have blown off- which was stupid of me, but…”

She couldn’t bring herself to be sorry that Bow had been able to find her.

“Anyway,” She said. “It was lovely getting to meet you.”

“You too,” He said. “I’ll see you tomorrow, alright?”

Glimmer smiled and handed him the rope. “Yes. Tomorrow. Here, I’ll lower you down.”

She held the rope while he, surprisingly gracefully, scaled the tower all the way down.

“Goodnight!” He called softly. She smiled.

“Goodnight, Bow.” She called back. “Goodnight.”

Chapter End Notes

Hi friends! Thank you for reading, please leave comments and/or Kudos if you feel so moved. I am available on Tumblr @somebodys-muse if you want to discuss any suggestions or thoughts you may have.

All my love,
Somebody's Muse

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He isn't coming back, Glimmer thought the next morning, trying to busy herself with washing dishes and folding laundry- trying to go about her business as usual, ignoring the fact that the only thing that had ever happened to her had happened just yesterday.

"Bow," She kept saying his name out loud to herself. He was tall and broad shouldered, with honey-brown skin and warm brown eyes- eyes that lit up when he was excited. He wanted to fight in the Rebellion, he had thirteen siblings…

Was she sure that Bow was real? Was it possible that he was just a figment of her imagination, a delusional product of her own boredom?

She tried to remember everything that had happened yesterday- she was holding onto a paintbrush and he just…stumbled into her tower.

She rolled her eyes. He wasn't coming back. Even if he was real, he wasn't coming back. He had a whole life- a whole set of goals and hobbies that couldn't be disturbed by some shut-in. She probably hadn't interested him enough to bring him back- he had just said that he would come back to be kind, like he had been kind to listen to her. She wasn't even interesting enough to keep

her own mother around for longer than a day or two, so why should Bow be any different?

She sighed. But it would have been nice if he were to come back. She liked talking to him- and she hadn't even asked him what his siblings did, what his dads were like…

"Glimmer!"

To her own embarrassment, she ran towards the window and looked downwards. Bow was standing at the foot of her tower.

"Bow!" She called back, lowering the rope to her tower. He looked up at her and smiled. She smiled back and felt a blush creeping on her cheeks. She hid her face while she he climbed upwards.

"Hi!" He said when he reached the top and climbed inside. "Sorry, it took longer than I thought it would, my dads made pancakes this morning, and that's always kind of a special occasion, then I forgot if I would see that giant tree first and then the brook or if it were the other way around, then-" He looked at her, seeing how intently she was looking at him.

"What's up?" He asked. "Are you alright?"

"Bow, are you real?" She blurted out.

He laughed. “Last I checked, yes.” He answered.

“That’s exactly what someone who wasn’t real would say,” She said skeptically.

“Well,” He took her hand in his, placing her palm flatly against his chest. “See for yourself.”

Glimmer felt his heart beating beneath her fingers, the warmth of his skin seeping into hers. She looked up at him.

“Real?” He asked.

“Real,” She confirmed, and finally let herself smile again. “You came back.”

“Of course,” He said. “I told you I would.”

“Well, yes, but…” She trailed off. “It’s just really good to see you.”

“You too,” He said. “Did you sleep alright?”

No one had ever asked her how she slept. Was that something people did?

"I slept just fine," She answered before she could ruminate too long. "How did you sleep?"

"Like a baby," He answered. "No one bothered you?"

"Not a soul," She said. "Thank goodness."

"Good," he said, relieved. "I was worried for you,"

If everyone was as sweet as Bow, she thought, *I wouldn't even need this tower.*

Thoughts of her tower brought her back to more practical matters.

"I was wondering," she said. "If you wanted me to show you around?"

"Ah, tower tour! That sounds great."

The Tower Tour didn't last very long- all she really had to show was her bedroom, the bathroom, and the kitchen since he had already been in the living room. One way or another, it served as

a way to get their conversation going- she had countless questions to ask him.

She learned that Bow's siblings were scattered around Etheria, but still managed to find their way back home for birthdays and holidays. His Dads met and fell in love while they were at school- their mutual friends had a running bet on when they would finally get together. His birthday was right before Winter started, he was only a few months older than she was.

"So, why archery?" She finally asked. The sun was about to set, casting the tower in a golden glow. She could see flecks of hazel in his eyes.

"Sword-fighting seemed like something that I couldn't hide from my Dads as well, and long-range weaponry just seemed more practical in general," He said. "And I modify my arrows- that's why I climbed up here yesterday, I wanted a place to work on them."

"Oh," Glimmer said. "So, you just find places in the Woods to practice and work?"

He nodded his head. "I know it's not a perfect system, but I don't want to risk my Dads finding them, and they've gotten messed up quite a few times, but that's the risk you run when you leave your prized possessions at the mercy of every critter roaming around the Whispering Woods."

“That must be hard,” She said.

He shrugged his shoulders. “I manage.”

She watched him take a slow sip of his tea before she spoke again.

“Bow?”

“Yes, Glimmer?”

“You can- well, if you want to, you can do your work here,” She said. “I mean, it’s not like I get whole lot of company, and…”

“Really?” Bow asked. “That’d- wow, that would be great. I mean- are you sure?”

“Of course I’m sure,” She said. “We’ll just have to hide your stuff if Mother ever comes back.”

Bow smiled and nodded his head. “Then- then yes, thank you. Thank you so much.”

Glimmer felt herself smiling back- it was impossible not to smile at Bow.

“My pleasure,” She said. “I’ll clear off the workbench tomorrow- I don’t use it that often anyway, since most of my paintings are on the walls-“ She noticed him staring at her, his smile replaced with a look of- was that concern? Confusion? Both? “I mean, you don’t have to if you don’t want to. I didn’t want to force you into anything.”

“No, it’s not that, of course I want to- you just- you said if she ever comes back?” He asked. “Is- are you doubtful?”

“Oh,” Glimmer said, understanding. “Of course not, it’s just been a while. And it’s not like she ever drops in for very long, anyway, but…”

She let her voice trail off, not wanting to tell Bow about the fact that her pantry was dwindling, or that she was almost out of toothpaste.

“Glimmer, can I ask you something?” He asked.

“Sure,” She said.

“What’s your mother like?”

Glimmer frowned. She had spent so long trying to understand her Mother- how on earth could she make sense of her to someone else?

"Well- I mean, she's- we don't look very much alike. She's- she's very tall, almost a foot taller than I am." She didn't know how to explain that she had never seen her mother's face. But she had a feeling that she had not inherited her short, soft stature from her mother. "And she's- well, she's smarter than I am."

"Why do you say that?"

"Just- just the way she talks," Glimmer tried to explain. "Like- well, she would know exactly how to tell you how she's smarter than I am. She's better with words- she's better at talking. I mean, she's probably had more practice-" She looked up at him and fell silent. "I'm rambling. I'm sorry, Mother says I ramble."

"You don't ramble," Bow said. "I mean, it's not bad if you do."

"It doesn't make me seem very smart," She argued. "Or well-spoken."

"Who told you that?"

"My- oh, you know who. Who's told me everything I know?"

“Well,” Bow said. “I think you’re smart.”

She smiled.

“So, she’s taller and smarter than you- what do you do better than she does?”

Glimmer furrowed her brow. “I don’t know. Probably nothing.”

“Why do you say that?”

“Because she’s a sorcerer whose business keeps her, well, busy- and like I said, she can actually string a sentence together without sounding like she’s never had a conversation with another person in her life.”

“There’s an unfair disadvantage there,” Bow pointed out. Glimmer shrugged and looked down at her lap.

“Is she kind?”

Bow hadn’t known Glimmer for very long, but he could still decipher her answer from what little he could see of her face before she said a word.

“Not like you are,” She answered, raising her head. “She’s- well, I mean, she put me here for a reason, so she cares about keeping me safe.”

“But she isn’t here very often?”

She shook her head.

“Glimmer, do you get lonesome?” He asked.

She raised her hand and shook out her hair so it created a curtain between her face and his.

Was she lonesome?

Why did he think she kept so busy?

She slowly nodded her head, finally admitting what she had never been brave enough to confront.

As much as she tried to be grateful for her tower, for her protection from the cruelties of the world, she was still lonely, and ashamed on top of it all.

He put his hand on her shoulder.

“Hey, it’s okay,” He said softly. “I didn’t mean to upset you-“

“You didn’t upset me,” She said far too quickly, her voice very nearly breaking with every word. “I just…”

He saw her wipe her eyes on her cuff.

“Oh, Glimmer,” He said. “I didn’t mean to- here.”

He dug a handkerchief out of his pocket, one that his brother had gifted him for his last birthday. His initials were embroidered on the corners.

“Here,” he said, handing it to her. She wiped her eyes again and took a deep breath.

“Sorry,” She said, finally letting herself look back at him. Her eyes were slightly red, but dry.

“Don’t be sorry,” He said.

“Here,” she said, handing him his handkerchief back.

“No, you hold onto it,” He said. “I have more at home, my brother made me a whole set. Most people would think that that means he loves me, but I think he just loves to embroider.”

Glimmer laughed.

“I’m glad you’re here, Bow,” She said after a moment. “I like having you here.”

“I like being here,” He said. “And now that you’ve offered me a workspace, you won’t be able to get rid of me.”

“Wouldn’t dream of it.” She said smoothly. “Would you tea like while you work?

“That would be great,” He said. She stood and walked towards the kitchen. Bow watched her for a moment before gathering his arrows and getting to work.

Chapter End Notes

Hi friends! Sorry for the shorter chapter this time- big things are coming up, I promise! I cannot tell you how happy all of your comments and Kudos have made me, it truly warms my heart. Please continue to leave your thoughts and feedback!

Side note: My birthday is in TWO DAYS!

I'll update soon, sometimes these crazy kids just write themselves.

All my love,
Somebody's Muse

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"If I could give you the moon,

I would give you the moon."

-Phoebe Bridgers, "Moon Song"

What had Bow done with his time before meeting Glimmer?

It had been almost two weeks of seeing her nearly every day. He left in the morning and went to her tower, and left before the sun set. Obviously the time and space to work on his arrows was welcome, but he found himself talking to her more than anything. Even when they weren't talking, it was a comfortable, shared silence.

But yesterday before he left, she asked him if he would mind staying away for one day- she just "had a feeling" that her mom was going to be back the next day. Bow had agreed; maybe she was just tired and needed a day to herself- her cheeks did look a little hollow, and she seemed a little more tired. Maybe he should bring her soup the next time he saw her.

He was even more surprised at how worried he was, not because he thought Glimmer didn't appreciate his company, and only partially because Glimmer was alone in her tower. What really bothered him was what she said: she "had a feeling" that her mom would be back the next day. That was the first time that he

fully realized that Glimmer didn't know when she would see her mom again. Of course, he was more than happy to keep her company, but what if he hadn't found her? Would she have gone almost two weeks without having talked to another person? Had this happened before?

He shook his head- maybe this was out of his depth. Maybe he should consult someone smarter.

Maybe two someones.

Both of his Dads were in the den when he opened the door- George was reading a book and Lance was playing solitaire.

"Dads?" He asked, stepping inside. "Can I ask you something?"

"Of course," George said, looking up from his cards. "What's on your mind?"

Bow sat in front of them, his back to the fireplace.

"Would it be healthy if- well, let's say, hypothetically, you had raised me on my own, and I hadn't interacted with anyone else outside of you two, would that be- you know, healthy for me? Developmentally?"

"Why would we have done that?" Lance asked, leaning forward.

“To- to keep me safe, I guess?”

His dads shared a glance.

“I- well, I don’t think that would be healthy, no,” Lance said. “You would miss interactions with people your age, to say nothing of the social skills you wouldn’t learn.”

“And you’d be lonely,” George added. “I mean, as much as we love you, we’re only two people.”

Glimmer only has one mom, he thought.

And he had a feeling that Glimmer’s mom didn’t love her the way his dads loved him.

“But- but would it be worth it if you knew I wouldn’t ever get hurt?”

“I think it’s a realization that we all have to come to as parents,” Lance supposed. “We can’t protect you from everything, baby. All we can do is give you all the tools and knowledge we can- that way, you can make the best decisions for yourself.”

“Besides, love, there’s not much harm that will come to you when you run a library,” George added. A sharp pang of guilt struck Bow in his abdomen- he tried to ignore it.

“Why do you ask?” Lance asked. “Is this for that research you’ve been so busy with?”

Bow nodded his head, grateful that he didn’t have to think of an explanation.

“You’ve been so busy with that- I can’t wait to see what you’ve discovered!” George said. Bow smiled.

“It’s definitely a discovery, for sure,” He said, standing. “I’m going to go to bed.”

“Goodnight, sweetheart,” George said. “Sleep well.”

“Goodnight, Dads.” Bow said.

He felt himself frown as soon as he wasn’t visible to his Dads anymore. Glimmer being locked away in a tower probably wasn’t for the best- she was missing out on the world.

But her mom didn’t want her exposed to the world, to all of the cruelties and confusions that came along with it.

But was it worth it?

He shook his head. If Glimmer wanted to stay in her tower, he wasn't going to force her out. Of course he would keep seeing her- even if all of his arrows weren't there, he still would have kept going back to her tower. He liked seeing her, and talking to her. He liked how her nose wrinkled when she laughed, how her eyes shone in the afternoon sunlight, how she knew just how much honey to put in his tea without making it too sweet.

And she was safe up there, and as long as she was safe and taken care of, he wouldn't say anything. After all, he didn't have any reason not to trust her mom's judgement- he had never met her, and he could ignore that feeling in his stomach.

Bow sat on his bed and looked out his window- the moon was shining brightly in the starless sky. Had Glimmer fallen asleep, or was she still awake? Was she looking at the same sky?

Go to bed, Bow. He told himself. *You'll see her tomorrow.*

The thought was enough to make him smile before he finally fell asleep.

oOo

What had Glimmer done all day before meeting Bow? She was amazed at just how empty her days alone seemed in hindsight- and even more amazed at how often Bow managed to come and see her, and how easy it was to look forward to seeing him. It had been almost two weeks, and she had seen Bow nearly every day.

He hummed while he worked. Glimmer noticed it a few days in- whenever Bow was concentrating extra hard, he started humming or, in a few cases, started singing under his breath.

She was shocked at how much she just liked *being* with him, even when they weren't talking. His mere proximity was enough to remind her that she wasn't alone.

Today, however, she was. Rain was pounding on her tower's roof, soaking the windowsill. She hoped that Bow was somewhere warm and safe and dry.

She sighed and turned towards her wall- the day before, she had finished a new sketch and was ready to paint over it. With Bow gone, her new mural was her favorite distraction from her stomach- her pantry situation had surpassed "depleted" and was quickly entering "empty" territory. Maybe asking Bow to stay behind yesterday had been wishful thinking, like she was sacrificing her time with him so her Mother would remember to feed her. Was she coming back?

Of course she's coming back, Glimmer told herself. *Stop worrying, you'll survive. Humans can go days without eating. You've barely gone eight hours.*

Glimmer sat before her wall and outlined the silhouette of the woman on the hill in black paint and painted her long curls a dark brown. She had almost finished the details of the darkened

garden when she heard her name, and saw Bow at the foot of her tower.

"Bow?" She tossed the rope down to him and pulled him upwards.

"What are you doing?" She asked. When he reached the window, she took his hand and helped him inside.

"I'm climbing a tower to see my friend Glimmer," He explained, like it was obvious. Droplets of rain were clinging to his eyelashes- how were his eyelashes so long? "She lives in a tower, but we've learned to work around that."

"Bow, it's pouring! Did you even bring a jacket?"

"I started walking before the rain started," He said. "So it seemed silly to turn back."

"Bow," She said, pinching the bridge of her nose. "You…you amaze me."

He smiled. "Thank you. Your hands are very warm."

Glimmer looked down and realized she was still holding onto his hand.

“You know you could have caught a cold, right?” She said, pressing his hand between both of hers.

“I wanted to see you,” He said. “I didn’t get to yesterday.”

Glimmer felt that stupid familiar blush creep onto her cheeks. Did he do that on purpose?

“I’ll get you a blanket,” She said. “Get away from the window, there’s still a chill.”

A few minutes later, Bow was sitting in his favorite armchair, one of her blankets wrapped around his shoulders.

“You look very cozy,” She said, handing him a mug of tea. “Though I don’t know if this tea will keep your hypothermia at bay.”

“I won’t get hypothermia,” He said. “Don’t fret about me.” He looked over her shoulder and saw her new painting. “Did you start that yesterday?”

“I did,” She said.

“It’s beautiful,” He asked, standing and walking towards the wall. Glimmer followed him, glad that he couldn’t see her blushing again.

“Thank you,” She said, sitting and setting one of her paintbrushes in a cup of water, cleaning blue paint off of the bristles. “It’s from a story that I used to read before I went to sleep,” She said. “It’s silly, I know, but it was very comforting when I was small, and I guess I’m still nostalgic for it.”

Bow sat down beside her. “Tell me a story, then.”

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. “Are you sure?”

“I like stories,” He said. “And I like hearing you talk. And maybe it will keep my hypothermia at bay. I’m very vulnerable right now.”

Glimmer smiled and picked her brush back up. “Well, once upon a time, there was a woman who lived in a palace, surrounded by a beautiful garden. And every night, she would go to her garden and watch the night sky. Her gardener had loved her since they were children, and had watched her while he worked for years, never knowing how to tell her how he felt. One night he felt that his heart would break if he went another day without holding her, and he vowed that he would bring the moon to her because she loved it so.”

“He was going to bring her the moon?”

Glimmer nodded her head and went on.

"The next day, he built the tallest ladder he could and tried to pull the moon down from the sky. Of course, he failed because- well, it's the moon. It's a little taller than a ladder."

Bow laughed.

"The next night, he made a net and tried to catch the moon, and failed again. Dejected and exhausted, he went into town the next morning, where he saw a vagabond playing in the village square. When he sang, people flocked around him to listen, and that gave him his last idea- he was sure that this would be the one. He went to the garden that night and sang a song to the moon, telling it about how his heart was full of love for a woman who loved the moon, and he wanted to give it to her to make her happy."

A moon song, Bow thought.

"Obviously, the moon didn't come down from the sky, and the gardener hung his head, ashamed and heartbroken." Glimmer went on. "When he looked up, the woman stood before him. She had heard him singing- and she was smiling. He told her that he was sorry, that he had tried, but he couldn't bring the moon to her. He couldn't bring her that which she loved, and he showed her his empty hands. The woman took his hands in her own and led him away from the garden. The gardener didn't understand, why was she smiling when he had failed to bring her the moon? She rested her head against his shoulder and told him that she watched the moon every night because it comforted her- it made her feel less alone when darkness fell."

“And then she wasn’t alone, because she had the gardener,” Bow realized. Glimmer nodded her head.

“And the gardener finally got to hold his beloved in his arms- and did so for the rest of his days. And- well, I mean, they lived happily ever after. Obviously.” She glanced at Bow, then at the half-painted wall. “I told you it was silly.”

“I liked it.” Bow said.

“He tried to bring her the *moon*,” Glimmer said. “It’s almost like he hadn’t studied astronomy. Or maybe he just wasn’t the sharpest arrow in the quiver.”

“He was in love. That can make people do foolish things.” Bow reminded her. “My Dad auditioned for my Dad's string quartet when they first met at school- he said that that was easier than talking to him or, you know, asking him if he wanted to have dinner.”

Glimmer smiled. “That’s a little more realistic than catching the moon.”

“I can’t argue with you there,” Bow supposed.

“So your Dad is musical?” She asked. “Wait, is this George or Lance?”

“Lance,” Bow said. “They both love music- my sister Melody is definitely the best musician of all of us, but we can all carry a tune, and most of us play an instrument.”

“Do you?” She asked.

“I play the violin,” He said. “I have since I was four.”

“That’s- wait, you play the violin?”

“Yes, ma’am.”

“And you’re an archer?”

“That too.”

“And you’re named Bow?”

“Yes?” He thought for a moment, then smiled. “Huh, that’s funny. I never realized that.”

Glimmer laughed. “Go work on your arrows, you. Unless you want me to tell you all of my old bedtime stories.”

“Well, I’ve got to save some for later,” Bow said. Glimmer rolled her eyes playfully and turned back to her painting.

Bow wasn’t sure how long he stayed focussed on his work, but when he looked up, the sun was setting and the rain had long since stopped.

“Shoot,” He said, standing. “Glimmer, I need to head back, I didn’t realize how late it- Glimmer?”

He looked over and saw Glimmer asleep in front of her painting, her hand curled under her round cheek. He smiled and quietly walked to her. When shifted in her sleep, her eyes remained closed.

"You're out like a light, sweet girl," He murmured, shaking his head. "On the floor, of all places."

As gently as he could, he scooped her into his arms and carried her out of the living room and into her bedroom, setting her down on her unmade bed.

“Goodnight, Glimmer,” He whispered, pulling her purple comforter over her shoulders. “If I can, I’ll come back tomorrow. Sleep well.”

Chapter End Notes

Hi sweet friends! It's so good to see you all again. Finally, some title justification! Also it's rained all week where I am, can you tell?

Anyway, as always, please leave Kudos and/or comments if you feel so moved, I am available on Tumblr @somebodys-muse if you prefer to communicate there. I love you all so much, and I am so thankful.

All my love,
Somebody's Muse

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Glimmer woke up the next morning, she couldn't remember how she had gotten into bed. She remembered talking to Bow about her painting, she remembered the sun getting lower and lower in the sky-

Had Bow carried her to bed?

No, she must have gotten up and walked to bed at some point after he left, there's no way he would have carried her to bed. She would have died from embarrassment.

But then again, it seemed exactly like something Bow would do.

And her covers were tucked around her.

Had he *tucked her in?*

"Bow…" She groaned, sitting up. Immediately, her head started hurting, and she was struck by how empty she was. It had been a full day since the pantry had emptied itself.

“Ouch…” She said, putting her hand to her aching head. As gingerly as she could, she walked to her kitchen and gave her pantry one last futile glance.

At least she still had tea leaves.

Glimmer drank a glass of water and tried to work on her painting, ignoring her aching head. When she heard her name called, she was almost disappointed when she heard Bow’s voice instead of her Mother’s. Nonetheless, she felt that familiar flutter of her heart as she pulled him upwards.

“Hi, you,” He said brightly as soon as he appeared in her window.

“Hi,” She said, hoping her smile was less weak than it seemed. “How did you sleep?”

“Very well,” He answered, climbing inside. “How did-“

He stopped talking and studied her for a moment.

“Bow?”

“Glimmer, don’t take this the wrong way, but you look- well, you look a little pale. Are you getting sick?”

“No, I’m fine,” She said. “I’m just kind of lightheaded.”

“Wait, what?” He said. “Have you eaten today?”

“I said I’m fine,” She said. “I’ll be fine, I’m sure she’ll be back tomorrow-“

Bow put his hands on her shoulders.

“When was the last time you ate?” He asked, his voice almost stern.

“It was just yesterday, before you showed up-“

“So, yesterday morning.” He said. “It’s been over 24 hours- look, I’ll be right back.”

“Wait, where are you going?” She asked, following him to the window.

“I’ll be right back,” He said, taking the rope in his hands and standing on the windowsill. “If she’s not feeding you, I will.”

“Bow, I told you I’m fine-“

“Your hands are shaking,” He said. “People’s hands don’t shake when they’re fine.”

“Bow, please-“

“Glimmer, I’ll be back in a second. You’ll feel better after you’ve eaten.”

And Glimmer had to admit- she did feel better after she ate. Less lightheaded, definitely. When she looked up, Bow was studying her.

“Are you watching me graze?” She asked. Bow half-smiled, but it didn’t quite reach his eyes. “What’s wrong?”

“You went a full 24 hours without eating,” He said. “What would you have done if I hadn’t shown up?”

“I would have waited,” She said. “Mother should be back-“

“You’ve been saying that for weeks,” He said. “Glimmer, I…”

He searched for words, but none seemed quite right. Now he finally had proof that Glimmer was being mistreated, but he couldn’t explain to her how, especially since she didn’t seem to understand the severity of what was happening.

“She didn’t feed you,” He finally said. “You could have died.”

“It takes longer than 24 hours without eating to starve, Bow,” She said.

“Glimmer, I don’t think your mom deserves the grace you’re giving her.”

Bow cringed at his lack of tact, but at least he had gotten the conversation going, at long last.

“Why not?” Glimmer asked. “Bow, she’s my mother.”

“I know,” He said. “But I don’t think she’s- Glimmer, she lied to you about the princess. Parents shouldn’t lie to their children.”

“I’m sure she was just mistaken,” Glimmer said, standing and brushing crumbs off of her blouse. Her voice sounded mostly steady, but she wouldn’t look at him. Bow stood and followed her.

“What if she wasn’t?” He asked. “The princess being kidnapped is common knowledge, and why would she lie to you about a baby being killed? That’s gratuitous, not to mention false.”

“I’m sure she has her reasons,” Glimmer said. “And I’m not exactly common, so common knowledge doesn’t necessarily apply to me.”

“Maybe it should.”

“Alright, what’s that supposed to mean?”

“Glimmer, I don’t think what your mom is doing to you is healthy.”

Glimmer’s brows furrowed together, and her expression changed to frustration- no, not frustration.

Glimmer looked *upset*. Almost sad.

“Alright,” She finally said. “How do you figure?”

“She’s lying to you, and she isn’t feeding you,” Bow reminded her. “And she’s keeping you locked away from the world?”

“She’s doing that to protect me!” She cried.

“Glimmer, look at the facts,” He said, putting his hands on her shoulders. “Just open your eyes for one second.”

She shook her head and refused to meet his gaze. He shook his head.

"I trust her," She said, using that voice that Bow had grown used to- the one she used when she was choosing to stay blind.

"She's given you no reason to trust her," Bow said.

"She's my mother."

And he knew that that would be the extent of her argument.

"Alright," He said, removing his hands from his shoulders and walking to the window. "You clearly don't want to listen to me."

Glimmer didn't move from where she stood, and couldn't bring herself to look at him as he took her rope in his hands and left. She heard his footsteps fade away long before she turned back towards and ran towards the window.

"Bow!" She cried. "Bow, I…"

She felt her knees hit the floor- he was gone. She had chased him away, she had pushed him away.

Was she being mistreated? She shook her head. She couldn't bring herself to wonder, not when she had just chased Bow, the only good thing that had ever happened to her- no, the only thing that had ever happened to her at all- away.

How could she have been so stupid?

Glimmer shook her head, stood, and walked back to her painting, preparing to resign herself to loneliness once more.

oOo

When Glimmer woke up the next morning, she felt better for a moment before all of the memories from the day before came flooding back towards her. The morning before, she had woken up nauseous and exhausted and with an aching head- now she was all of those things, but Bow was gone.

She shook her head and got out of bed. She considered making a cup of tea before realizing how lonely that would make her. Instead, she sat in front of her window, staring at the clouds. She barely noticed when her name was called- this time, it wasn't Bow.

It’s about time, she found herself thinking as she pulled her Mother into her tower. She had forgotten what it was like to pull someone into the tower- Bow always climbed upwards.

“Hi,” Glimmer said breathlessly when she reached the top. She was exactly the same- still tall and dark and masked. So nothing bad had happened to her to delay her arrival.

“Hello, my pet,” She said back, setting a basket on the kitchen counter before sitting down on the sofa.

Glimmer watched her for a long moment, her fists clenched at her sides. Her mother remained silent.

Glimmer nodded her head and didn’t move from where she stood for a long moment, trying to make sense of everything that she felt in that moment.

“Do you need something?” Her mother asked, looking up at her.

“I- do I need anything?” She sputtered. “I- are you- what? You’ve been gone for weeks! Aren’t you going to explain where you were?”

“I didn’t realize that was so important to you,” She said smoothly. Her tone pushed Glimmer away from aggravation and straight into anger.

“Of course it’s important to me! You’re the only person that I get to talk to, and you aren’t even here most of the time!”

“That’s our arrangement,” She said, barely even noticing her child’s angry tone.

“It’s your arrangement,” Glimmer said stoutly. “I- did you know that…Mother, it’s- three weeks is a long time to be alone.”

“And yet, you soldier on,” She said. Glimmer blinked tears out of her eyes- how could she be so callous?

“Mother, I’m lonesome,” She said. “And- and that should matter to you. Doesn’t that matter to you?” She demanded.

Her mother rose from the sofa and started to walk towards Glimmer, who immediately recoiled.

“I wasn’t going to dignify your tantrum with a response,” She said. “But fine, because you so obviously crave some kind of audience, let’s talk about your loneliness.”

“Mother, I-“

“Tell me, Glimmer,” she said. “What do you need?”

"I-"

"Because I honestly can't think of a single thing you need, which means this is about something you want. You want something more than this home that I've given you- you want something more than to be safe from the outside world."

Glimmer couldn't find words and just kept staring upwards at her masked face.

"Don't you have everything you want? I seem to remember a child who wanted to paint and embroider and sew- and I see evidence of it all across her tower."

Glimmer tightened her fists.

"Do you know what happens to children who don't have a safe place to live?" She asked. "They fare far worse than you do, and they face far worse hardships than mere loneliness."

The sheer disdain in her voice when she said 'loneliness' made Glimmer feel like she was four years old, being chastised for almost taking off her necklace.

"But perhaps you'd prefer it outside, perhaps you'd prefer a war-torn planet where children are ripped from their parents in the

dead of night and are trained like animals to obey the Horde- would you prefer that to your life here? Would you prefer that to the warmth and comfort of your home?”

Glimmer fought to hold her gaze.

“Would you?” She asked. “Answer me.”

Glimmer’s courage broke, and she lowered her head.

“No,” She said softly.

“Louder, please.”

“No, mother.” She said, raising her voice slightly.

“Then tell me, my foolish child, why do you whine?”

Glimmer swallowed and blinked tears from her eyes instead of answering.

“Why do you whine about being lonesome because your mother- who has given you everything a child could possibly want, to say

nothing of safety from the outside world, can't spend every moment of her time with you?"

Glimmer searched for words- it wasn't just that she wasn't there, it was that she didn't hug her. She didn't ask her questions, she didn't even treat her like she was a person-

Stop, she told herself. *You'll just make her angry- stop being selfish. You have everything you need. Stop being foolish, stop being selfish.*

"I'll be gone longer again this time," She said, walking past her. "A week, perhaps longer."

Glimmer nodded her head, willing herself not to ask why she had to go so soon.

"Goodbye, my pet," She said.

"Mother, I-" She said, turning and walking towards the window.

"Not now, child," She said, taking the rope in her hands, the same way that Bow had. Glimmer bit her trembling lip and dropped her gaze again, unable to watch another person leave.

She wasn’t sure how long she stood, stuck on her floor in front of the window, before she finally managed to unclench her fists and walk to her bedroom. She sat in front of her bed and put her head in her hands.

Selfish, foolish- stupid, stupid, stupid!

Why did she always do this? Why did she always have to ruin everything? Of course she had mixed emotions towards her mother, but after she had alienated Bow, she was all she had left.

Maybe she *deserved* to be lonesome.

Glimmer glanced over and saw Bow’s handkerchief, the one he had given her weeks ago, on her bedside table. She picked it up and felt his initials, embroidered with red and gold thread.

Bow would return for his arrows, she was sure, but that would be the last time she saw him. He would go on with his life and would forget about her- would forget about the girl in the tower. This piece of fabric was all she would have to remember him by.

She crumpled it in her fist, held it against her heart, and finally let herself cry- for her own stupidity, for her own selfishness.

Chapter End Notes

Hello dears,

Do you ever listen to "tolerate it" by Taylor Swift and really think about the nature of abuse and neglect and gaslighting and it accidentally rubs off on the content of your fanfic? Me neither.

How is everyone doing? I hope you're all staying well and busy and taking care of yourselves. Have some ~angst~ free of charge. As always, I am available on Tumblr @somebodys-muse if any of you wish to communicate, and I ALWAYS ALWAYS ALWAYS appreciate Kudos and comments, of course.

I made my roommates watch Tangled a couple of nights ago- the lantern scene remains one of the most beautiful scenes in cinematic history.

All my love,
Somebody's Muse

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow sighed. He hadn't slept the night before and felt too guilty to eat- his dads were worrying that he was getting sick.

He hadn't seen Glimmer in almost two days- was she still upset with him? She had every right to be. As frustrated as he had been- as frustrated as he still was- he had to admit that he had handled the situation poorly.

Couldn't Glimmer see that she wasn't in a good situation?

No, how could she? It was the only situation she had ever known, and it wasn't like she had very much control- she was a victim. And he had gotten angry with her.

Had he raised his voice? He would never forgive himself if he had raised his voice at her.

He probably wouldn't forgive himself, anyway.

And what hurt more was that he missed her. Was her hair in a ponytail today, or was it loose, hanging around her shoulders? Was it falling into her face like it always did?

He should apologize.

But he still stood by everything he said- he knew that Glimmer wasn't nearly as safe as she was lead to believe, especially since her guardian had forgotten to feed her.

Maybe Glimmer had to come to that realization herself.

And he would help her- when she was ready, he would be there.

But first, he should apologize. How did people normally apologize?

He glanced out his opened bedroom door and saw a bouquet of bright blue hydrangeas sitting on one of his dad's end tables.

Maybe that was a good place to start.

oOo

As much as Glimmer had tried to prepare herself to see Bow one last time, hearing him call her name in the morning sent a shock through her system that hurt like physical pain.

He had barely waited two days, he must have really wanted to get their last meeting over with.

Glimmer took a shaky breath and lowered the rope. This was the last time she would see him, and she wasn't going to cry. He wouldn't know that his absence was going to break her heart.

"Hi," He said when he reached the top. "I- I brought you something."

She stared at him for a long moment, not quite understanding what he was holding out to her.

"You brought me flowers?" She finally said.

"I- yes," He said. He looked nervous. "I just- I felt bad about leaving the way I did last time, and I thought that these would… I'm just really, really sorry, Glimmer."

"No, don't be," Glimmer said, stepping closer to him, the flowers hanging between them. "You didn't do anything wrong."

"I shouldn't have gotten upset with you, though," He said. "It's- none of this is your fault."

“Maybe not,” She said. “But I don’t- I don’t know what to think, Bow. I’m- I’m just…really confused about a lot right now. I’m sorry.”

“Don’t be sorry for being confused.”

“I’m not sorry for being confused,” She said. “I’m sorry for- I’m sorry that I’m like this.”

“Like what?”

“I’m sorry that I’m selfish,” She finally said. “I’m so sorry, Bow.”

“Why would you say that?” Bow asked, taken aback by just how ashamed she looked. She wouldn’t even look him in the eye.

“Because I am,” She said softly. “And foolish.”

“What?” Bow asked. “Glimmer, who-“

He already knew who had told her those falsehoods.

“Glimmer?” He asked. “Do you trust me?”

She nodded her head, still not looking at him.

"Then please, please believe me when I tell you that you aren't foolish," He said. "And absolutely not selfish- you're the least selfish person I've ever met."

Glimmer wanted to protest- he was just being kind, he didn't realize-

It dawned on her- Bow *did* realize. Bow knew her in ways that her mother didn't, he knew her in ways she had never tried to know her.

Maybe she wasn't the problem. Maybe- just maybe, her mother had been wrong about her. She had been wrong about the princess being killed, too.

Then what else could she be wrong about?

"Do you- do you want me to stop coming here?" Bow asked.

Glimmer's head snapped upwards, her eyes wide.

"What? No!" She said, her eyes wide. She kicked herself internally- there went remaining cool and collected. "I thought you wouldn't want to anymore, and I wouldn't have blamed you-"

“Of course I still want to,” Bow said, using his non-flower-holding hand to brush a strand of hair out of her face.

“Well- that’s good, then.” She said. Bow smiled as she took the nosegay out of his hands.

She was struck, all of a sudden, at how different Bow’s homecoming was from her mother’s. Bow had apologized, he had listened to her. He realized that what he did had hurt her- even if he hadn’t meant to.

Why did her mother act so differently? Why did she feel cold when she had entered the tower, but felt so warm and safe in Bow’s presence?

Why did being with Bow feel safer than being in her tower?

“These are lovely,” She said to her flowers, pulling herself out of her thoughts.

“I thought the roses would bring out your eyes,” He said, gesturing towards the light purple blooms. She felt herself blush- why was he always making her blush? How could she be blushing at a time like this? “And my dads grow hyacinths every year.”

“Are the hydrangeas theirs, too?” She asked, walking into the

kitchen and taking a vase from the cupboard.

"No, apparently there was a florist on his way to Bright Moon. A lot of people buy flowers for the princess's birthday."

"Wait, really? That's- that's coming up?"

Bow nodded his head. "Tomorrow."

"Oh," Glimmer said. "I- I didn't realize that it was so soon."

"This is year number 18, too." He said. "Apparently it's supposed to be extra special. Though George doesn't think that any day commemorating a missing child can be special, and the celebrations are probably gouache- hey, what's the matter?"

"Nothing," She said, shaking her head. "I just…I don't know. Every year I watch from my window, but…"

How could she explain to him that her tower was becoming more and more unbearable by the minute? How could she tell him that she was tired of being talked down to by a woman who was almost never present- how could she tell him that she felt like she was waking up from a long, hazy dream?

How could she tell him that he made her brave?

“I don’t know, I want to see them for real. Like…” She looked at the ground.

“Like what?”

“It’s stupid,” She said, not meeting his gaze.

“I won’t think it’s stupid,” He said. “C’mon, you can tell me.”

“I just feel like- like I should see the enchanted sky in person tomorrow. And it has to be this year. And it has to be in person,” She explained, glancing out her window.

Bow looked at her thoughtfully for a moment.

“So, why don’t you go?” He asked.

“Are you kidding? Mother would skin me alive,” She said. “But…” She looked at him. “She said she wouldn’t be back for a week, at least.”

“Alright?”

“How about another business venture?” She asked, turning towards him fully. “In exchange for accompanying me to Bright Moon- no, that’s stupid, never mind, I can’t leave-“

“Huh?” Bow asked. “Wait, why not? This is a great idea!”

“I’m in a tower for a reason!” She said. “And Mother would kill me- but if she doesn’t know…”

“I can get you there and back in two days,” He said. “Obviously, if you aren’t comfortable going, I won’t make you. But I will go with you if you do.”

“But- but what if something happens?” She asked. “What if someone tries to-“

“Hey,” He said, putting his hands on her shoulders and stooping down so she wouldn’t have to look up at him. “I won’t let anything happen, okay? I’ll protect you the whole time- I won’t even leave your side.”

Glimmer took a deep breath. “Are you sure?”

“I promise,” He said.

“Alright,” She said, glancing around the tower. “I trust you.”

And she did. No harm would come to her as long as Bow was with her.

“When can we leave?” She asked.

“Tomorrow morning,” He said. “I’ll figure out some excuse to tell Dads- let’s find what’s waiting for you at Bright Moon.”

Glimmer’s face broke into a grin. She started laughing, then wrapped her arms around his middle.

“Thank you, I-“ She stopped laughing and stepped back. “Goodness, I’m so sorry. That was- I’m sorry, I didn’t- I normally-“

“Glimmer,” Bow interrupted. “Come here.”

“Are you sure?” She asked. Bow nodded his head, and opened his arms.

Glimmer found herself wondering, as she entered his embrace, if anyone had ever hugged her before. As far as she could remember, no one had.

Bow's arms were completely around her, and he was holding her tightly. And it seemed like he wasn't waiting for her to let go- it seemed like he didn't want to let go. Tentatively, she placed her arms around his middle and pressed her face into his chest. He smelled like vanilla and trees and fresh air.

"Thank you," She said. "Just- just thank you."

"Don't mention it," He said. She lifted her head off of his chest so she could meet his eyes.

"We're really going to Bright Moon tomorrow," She said softly, shaking her head.

"We're going to Bright Moon tomorrow,' He confirmed. "To see the enchanted sky."

"To see it in person," She said, a nervous smile on her lips. "For real."

Bow pulled her closer again.

"For real."

Chapter End Notes

Hello dears!

Well, here we are! We are about to leave the tower! Who's excited? Who's ready for some ~clarity~?

Also ahhhhh sorry it's a short chapter! I'm sure all two of my readers will be devastated.

So I love flowers (I buy new flowers and make bouquets to put around my apartment every week, it's lucky I work in a grocery store and have access to bargain bin flowers) and I especially love the symbolism of flowers and the messages they convey. Here is a translation for the bouquet of flowers Bow gave Glimmer:

Hyacinths: "I'm sorry, please forgive me."

Purple roses (every color means something different, be wary of that): "You enchant me."

Hydrangeas: General gratitude and grace. (Today they are also my favorite flowers, if any of you are wondering.)

Anyway, what kinds of flowers do you all like? Please leave comments and kudos if you feel so moved, I cannot tell you how dear your words are to me.

All my love,
Somebody's Muse

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer was pacing around her tower the next morning. It was one of the prettiest days she had ever seen- the sky was a perfect azure blue and only the slightest breeze rattled the trees.

For the first time in her life, she was going to feel the full warmth of the sun on her skin. This was the day she had waited for for her entire life.

She gasped aloud when Bow appeared in her window.

"Good morning," He said, smiling. Glimmer put her hand over her racing heart and helped him inside. "Did I startle you?"

"A little," She admitted. "Or maybe I'm just a little jumpy."

"Ah," Bow said.

"Anyway," She said. "How are you?"

“I’m- I’m great,” He said, finally getting the chance to look at her fully. “You- wow, you look…”

Glimmer raised her eyebrow, asking him to continue, but he couldn’t quite find words. She looked different, not better, she always looked nice, but there was something about the way she was smiling, the way her ruffled blouse exposed her shoulders, how the purple rose she had put in her hair stood out against her dark waves- but she looked different.

“You’re so pretty, Glimmer,” He said finally. She laughed.

“You’re sweet,” She said. “Wait, before I forget.”

She took another flower, one of the roses, and pinned it in place on his shirtfront.

“Now we match,” She said brightly. He smiled.

“Are you ready to leave?” He asked. “It’s not a long jaunt to Bright Moon, but the sooner we get going, the better.”

Glimmer nodded her head. “Yes. I am ready to leave. I am not terrified at all.”

“Hey,” Bow said. “I promised you I wouldn’t let anything happen to you, didn’t I?”

Glimmer nodded her head. “You did. And I trust you.”

Bow smiled and went to her window again. “I’ll meet you outside?”

“Of course,” She answered. “Go on.”

Glimmer looked around her tower while Bow climbed downwards. It was all she had known for all of her life, and regardless of what happened, that was about to change. She was about to know more. When she came back to her tower at the end of the day, she would be a changed person.

Glimmer turned away from her tower, took the rope in her hands, and took a deep breath as she left her tower for the first time.

“Welcome back,” Bow said as she reached the ground. Glimmer barely heard him, she was too busy taking in her surroundings.

This is what the sun felt like on her skin. This is how the wind felt in her hair.

“Oh, my goodness,” She said softly. “I’m not in my tower anymore.”

“You aren’t,” Bow told her. “Welcome to the world.”

Glimmer heard herself laughing- she wasn’t in her tower anymore! She was outside! She was in the world!

Then she heard her Mother’s voice in her head again: The world is dangerous, there are children who fare far worse…

Then she looked at Bow, who was smiling at her and watching her with such fondness in his eyes.

“I’m not in my tower anymore,” She said softly, looking up at him. Bow nodded his head and took her hand in his.

“I’m right here,” He promised her. Glimmer nodded her head- as long as she was with Bow, she couldn’t help feeling anything but totally and completely safe.

oOo

Bright Moon was…overwhelming.

Glimmer had wondered what the world outside her tower would feel and look like for years, and for the most part, she had been correct. But her fantasies had never extended towards other villages, and certainly not towards crowds of other people.

And Bright Moon was *noisy*. It was beautiful, of course, with its towering buildings and people laughing and talking and bustling around, someone was even playing music somewhere- but still, she couldn't help but feel overwhelmed as she and Bow ventured further and further into the city.

"Are you alright?" Bow asked.

Glimmer looked up at him and smiled. "I'm fine," She said. "It's- it's a lot to take in."

"I know," He said almost apologetically. "This is probably Bright Moon's busiest day of the year-"

"I love it," She realized aloud. "It's- it's so beautiful here."

Bow smiled. "I'll take you to the shrine- that's where they put the royal portrait."

In the village square, there was a mosaic of the last royal portrait of the princess and her two parents. King Micah and Queen Angella stood together, their regality barely hiding their joy at

being in love and being new parents. The people of Bright Moon had placed flowers at the bottom of the mosaic, hundreds of blooms in shades of pink and purple to match the sky they would see that evening.

"She has pink hair," Glimmer remarked, twisting a lock of her own dark hair around her finger.

"It's a princess thing," Bow explained. "Apparently, she could teleport when she was just a baby. She had so much magic."

"Wow, teleportation? I *wish* I could teleport." She squinted to read the engraving at the mosaic's bottom, obscured by the many flowers. "For the late king…King Micah passed away?"

"Years ago," Bow answered. "During the first princess alliance- it was a huge blow to the kingdom, and to the Rebellion."

"Queen Angella lost her husband and her child?" Glimmer asked. "That's awful."

"The princess isn't lost," Bow said, squeezing her hand. "She's missing."

"Your optimism is admirable," She said. The music she had heard earlier had grown louder- there was a violinist a few yards away, playing for a steadily increasing crowd of people.

Bow tugged at her hand, pulling her towards him.

"Come on," He said. "Dance with me."

"Bow, I've never-"

"It's okay, I have," He said. "I'll lead."

Glimmer rolled her eyes- how could she say no to him when he looked so precious? He put his hand on her waist and took her other hand in his, leading her in a simple, quick waltz.

"You're good at this," Glimmer observed.

"My dads had us all take lessons for my sister Flora's wedding," He explained.

Glimmer nodded her head and looked around at the crowd around them, at the way they looked at one another and laughed and talked, like nothing was wrong in their beautiful kingdom, like nothing was wrong in their beautiful world.

"You're making your thinking face," Bow said.

“I have a thinking face?”

He nodded his head. “Your brow furrows- don’t worry, it’s endearing.”

Glimmer gave him a short smile before her brows knitted together again.

“What’s up?” He asked.

“I just- all of these people,” She said. “The whole thing with the Horde has probably lasted their whole lives. And Queen Angella is still the head of the Rebellion even after losing her daughter and her husband- I just don’t understand how they do it. How they keep going even when there’s so much tragedy.”

“I think that’s why you have to keep going,” Bow said thoughtfully. “We all know that by existing, we run risks of getting hurt, especially when the world is at war.”

Glimmer looked around at the couples dancing around them- they were smiling and laughing with one another. They knew how cruel the world could be- they had grieved alongside their queen, and all of their lives had been marred by the Horde in some way.

But they kept dancing.

Glimmer felt herself smile. Bow pulled her closer, resting her against his chest.

"It's not so bad out here," she said softly. "As long as you keep dancing."

He smiled and rested his chin on top of her head, wishing that he would get to keep dancing with Glimmer, even when their day in Bright Moon came to a close.

He held her closer, and they kept dancing.

oOo

It pained her to admit it, but sometimes Angella couldn't remember everything about Glimmer. She remembered how her beautiful eyes sparkled, how her laugh was always enough to make her smile, how her own heart broke when she cried…

But 18 years, alongside the loss of her husband, had taken a toll on her memory.

She was a queen of a kingdom at war. She was a widow. And she had lost her baby girl- her only daughter, her only child.

She blinked tears from her eyes and glanced at the photograph on her nightstand- their portrait had been done only a few weeks after Glimmer had been born. She and Micah and their daughter were smiling and holding one another. Glimmer already looked like Micah- she had his round cheeks and his smile. She would give anything to see that smile again.

But here she was, 18 long years later, clinging to the memories of her daughter. Sometimes she wanted to scream from the injustice of it all- someone who probably had little regard for Glimmer, for her magic and for her love, got to have her, while she, who had only ever loved her, was chasing fading memories.

She looked at the sky. The sun was setting, and soon night would fall.

And she would cast a spell for her daughter. She would make the sky shine as beautifully and as brightly as her eyes had, and she would cast imaginary stars that would sparkle for her namesake.

And maybe somewhere out there in the wide, endless world, Glimmer would see the sky and know it was for her.

And maybe she would come home.

Angella took a deep breath and stepped onto the palace balcony. Her people were gathered in the village below her, looking upwards. Parents were clinging to their children more tightly, her loss reminding them of their blessing.

She looked up at the sky and pressed her hand to her lips.

"For you, my Glimmer." She whispered. "I miss you immensely- and love you even more."

She raised her hand- and the sky erupted. If she pretended, she could pretend that she was looking into her long lost child's eyes, not at an imitation.

Come home, my love. She pleaded to the imaginary stars.

oOo

"You're sure we're allowed up here?"

Bow held out his hand and helped Glimmer onto the balcony. The house where he and his family had lived was vacant, and it still had its balcony. Climbing up the old trellis in the garden had been easy enough, and luckily it still reached the bottom of their old balcony. He remembered his brothers using it to climb in and out of the house.

“No one else lives here- they wouldn’t begrudge me a visit to my childhood home.” He said. “And it’s the best day of your life, I don’t want anyone obstructing your view.”

“Because I’m short?” She asked.

“Because you are finding something in Bright Moon,” He said smoothly.

“Right,” She said, glancing down at her hands. “So- so you used to live here?”

He nodded his head. “I don’t remember it very much, we left when I was so young.”

“It’s nice,” she said. “So- oh…”

Bow looked away from Glimmer and looked upwards- the sky around the palace wasn’t blue anymore.

And quickly, the whole sky erupted. Queen Angella had painted it every shade of pink and purple and dotted it with perfect, glittering stars. Bow turned back to Glimmer. Her mouth hung open, the imitation stars reflecting in her eyes.

“Oh…” She breathed. Bow smiled and turned his own gaze towards the sky.

He wondered, for a moment, if the princess could see the newly-painted sky. He hoped- for Angella’s sake, that she was somewhere out there.

He heard Glimmer gasp beside him- her inhale sharp and sudden. He glanced over at her and was immediately taken aback.

Glimmer was crying, tears streaming down her face as she stared upwards. She noticed him looking at her and tried to compose herself.

“Sorry,” She said, roughly wiping her cheeks. It did her no good- her tears were falling fast and thick.

“Are you alright?” He asked softly.

“Mhmm,” She said, not at all convincingly. “It’s just…the sky is really beautiful…” She let out a sob. “It’s p-perfect…”

She buried her face in her hands and let herself weep.

“Hey,” Bow said. “Glimmer, what’s wrong?”

“Nothing,” she said, her voice muffled by her hands and her tears.

“Not nothing,” he said. “Please tell me what’s wrong? Please?”

She shook her head again. Normally, Bow wouldn’t have pushed her anymore, but here she was on the happiest night of her life, followed by the happiest day of her life, and she was crying like her heart was broken. Not wanting to block her view of the sky, he knelt before her.

“Please look at me,” he said softly. “Don’t hide your face from me.”

Reluctantly, Glimmer removed her hands from her face, the beautiful light of the purple sky reflecting on her tears. He took her hands in his.

“Tell me what’s wrong, sweetheart.” He said.

“I’ve had the best day of my life,” She said. “And I’ve never seen anything more beautiful in my life, and you…you’re so good, Bow. You’re the best thing that’s ever happened to me…” She looked down at their intertwined hands. “But I didn’t find anything. And now I have to go back to the tower and just keep watching, wondering how I missed it.”

“Glimmer,” He said seriously, brushing a wet strand of hair off of her rosy cheek. “You don’t have to go back.”

“Huh?” She hiccuped. “What?”

“You don’t have to go back to that tower,” He said, holding her hands tighter. “I- you can come home with me. My dads will love you, and I- I won’t let anything happen to you,” He said. “I know you’re scared, and I understand, but…but I would look after you. I’ll keep my promise.”

She sniffed and tried to tell him “No,” that she had to go back, that her Mother would be upset with her, that it was too dangerous-

But Bow was looking at her, and he was so beautiful, and so wonderful, and he was offering her exactly what she wanted. What she had always wanted.

“Okay,” She said. “I’m- I’m not going back.”

Both of their faces broke into identical grins. Bow reached forward and pulled her into his arms, lifting her off of her feet.

“I’m not going back!” She laughed, burying her face in the crook of his neck. “I- I get to stay with you!”

Bow gently set her back down, keeping his arms around her waist.

"I'll stay with you," He told her. "If that's what you want."

"It is," She said honestly. He felt his heart swell; she was prettier than any sky he had ever seen, even the enchanted ones. And she was smiling- that was all he wanted to do, to see her smile and make her smile. It was his favorite thing he had ever done.

And then his smile was inching closer to hers, and she was leaning in towards him, and his hand reached out, almost instinctively, to stroke her perfect cheek.

And then he was kissing her. And she was kissing him, and he would get to kiss her again and again and again.

They broke apart and Glimmer looked up at him, still smiling that smile.

"I'm not going back," She said softly, resting her forehead against his.

"You never have to go back," He assured her, pulling her against his chest. "Oh, ouch…"

“What?” Glimmer asked. “What’s wrong?”

“Nothing,” He said. “Your necklace pressing against my ribcage kind of hurts, but-“

Glimmer looked down at her necklace. FI she was never going back to her tower, she didn’t have to keep it on anymore.

She was free.

Glimmer took her necklace’s pendant in her hand and pulled downwards, breaking the chain that had stayed around her neck for eighteen years. She let it fall beside her onto the floor of the balcony. Bow’s eyes widened.

“What’s wrong?” She asked. “Bow?”

“Glimmer, your hair looks…”

“What?” She asked, self-consciously putting a hand on her head. “What’s wrong with it?”

“Nothing- it’s- Glimmer, your hair is pink.”

“Bow, don’t be silly,” She said.

“No, see for yourself.”

Glimmer took hold of one of her tresses and studied it.

“Well,” She said slowly. “That’s- my hair is pink. Why is it pink?”

“I don’t- when you took your necklace off, it changed…”

Glimmer looked down at the pendant, laying there at her feet.

“Maybe it’s just a trick of light,” She said. “I almost wish I could run back to the tower, there’s a mirror-“

Glimmer gasped- the world went black for a split second.

And she was standing in front of the mirror in her tower.

“What just- Bow?” She called, trying to keep the rising panic out of her voice. “Bow!”

But she was alone in her tower- how on earth had she gotten

there so quickly?

Glimmer’s heart started pounding in her chest as she looked at her reflection, at her glowing magenta hair, and was her skin sparkling in the low light of the moon?

Glimmer had pink hair. And apparently she could teleport- she was hidden away from the world when she was a baby, and her name…she and Bright Moon’s princess…

“I am the lost princess,” She realized aloud. “I’m the lost princess.”

“Ah, that’s my clever child.”

And Glimmer’s mother stepped into view behind her.

Chapter End Notes

hi everyone! here's another chapter for your reading pleasure, I'm afraid I didn't quite capture the magic of the lantern scene from Tangled, but I DID listen to that musical number while I wrote.

speaking of, I'm in a musical that opens on Friday!

anyway, I love you all very much, please leave kudos and comments if you feel so moved.

all my love,
Somebody's Muse

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bright Moon was a blur around Bow as he ran back to the Whispering Woods.

Had Glimmer teleported?

Glimmer could teleport?

The last thing he heard her say was that she wished she could see a mirror, and she had mentioned the one in her tower-

He had to go back to her tower, he had promised her that she would never have to go back-

Everything had happened so fast, first he was kissing her, then her hair was pink, then she was gone…

"Oh no…" He realized, skidding to a halt. "Glimmer is…"

And everything made sense all at once- her pink hair, her name, the fact that she wasn't allowed to see the outside world-

And she was back in her tower- what if her mom (should he call her that? Glimmer's mom was the queen of Bright Moon), the woman who had kidnapped her, was there?

That uneasy feeling in his stomach increased tenfold- the lost princess was in danger.

Glimmer was in danger.

And he had to go save her.

oOo

"How could you?" Glimmer asked, whirling around to face her Mother. "How could you?"

"I suppose it's time for us to finally have a mother-daughter talk," She said, grabbing Glimmer's arm and pulling her away from the mirror. "Honestly it didn't take much, my pet. All I had to do to hide the truth from you for 18 years was magic your hair darker- but getting you here was even simpler."

"I don't-"

"The late King Micah was one of my students- reasonably gifted, I suppose, but painfully narrow-minded by way of what magic could really do. His foolishness cost me dearly- I nearly lost all of my

magic to it.” She took another step towards Glimmer, backing her against the wall, the same wall that featured her Moon Song painting. “And I think he and his queen knew that.”

She laughed- Glimmer could count how many times she had heard her mother laughing on one hand, but her story was filling her with such mirth that it echoed against the tower walls.

“Your foolish parents didn’t even try to hide you from me! They left you out in the open, so defenseless. You were mine for the taking, they knew that I was entitled to your magic.”

“To my magic?” She asked.

“Speaking of, where is your necklace?” She asked, looking between Glimmer’s collarbones.

“Why does that- oh…” Glimmer realized, all of a sudden, why she was always made to wear her necklace, why her pendant had stopped glowing when she had taken it off, why her hair had turned back to its natural shade.

Her mother didn’t have magic- she had been using hers.

“Where is it, my pet?”

“I’m not your pet,” Glimmer spat. “I’m not even your daughter.”

“I will ask you one more time,” She said again, leaning further towards Glimmer. “Where is-“

“Glimmer!”

Both Glimmer and her Mother turned towards the window and saw that the rope was hanging outside, and it was pulled taut, like someone was climbing upwards.

“Bow-“ Glimmer said aloud before she could stop herself. Her mother turned back to her.

“You’re going to make this difficult,” She realized. Glimmer tried to push past her, but something kept her pressed against the wall- she couldn’t move.

She saw her Mother’s necklace glowing just slightly- she still had some magic, and she was using it to restrain her.

“Wait right here,” She said. “I’ll greet your friend properly.”

When Bow reached the top of the rope and stumbled into her tower only a few seconds later, Glimmer was, for the first time, devastated to see him.

“Glimmer?” He asked. “Glimmer, what’s-“

“Bow, look out!”

Bow felt someone press against him form behind before there was a terrible pain in his abdomen. He crumpled to the ground, clutching his bleeding middle.

“Bow!” Glimmer screamed. Her mother stepped out from behind his fallen form, still brandishing one of their kitchen knives.

“Look what you’ve done, foolish child,” Her mother chastised, stepping over his body. “Your selfishness has killed the only friend you’ve ever had.”

“How could you?” She looked up at her, her eyes filled with tears.

“I would have used my magic, but unfortunately, I’m a bit weak right now, especially after having to keep you in place- but that’s beside the point. We’re leaving- we have to make a new vessel and find somewhere new- somewhere where your foolishness can never harm anyone ever again.”

“I’m not going with you,” Glimmer snapped. “I will never, ever let you use my magic ever again.”

“When, child, will you realize that you don’t have a choice? What can you do outside of this tower? What will you do outside of my protection, outside of these walls that have housed you for so long?”

“I- I’ll teleport away,” Glimmer cried. “And you’ll never see me ever again.”

She laughed again. “We both know that you won’t be able to do that- your magic isn’t strong enough. You aren’t strong enough, my pet. You don’t know how.”

Glimmer took a breath, blinking tears out of her eyes. She had only teleported once, and it had been on accident- she wasn’t strong enough.

Then she remembered what she had learned that day: the princess had had copious magic when she was only a baby.

And Glimmer was strong.

And Bow needed her.

“You’re wrong about me,” She spat, taking a step forward. Her kidnapper didn’t recoil, and neither did she. “Everything you told

me about people, about the world, about me- is wrong. And I don't trust you anymore."

Glimmer took her mother's necklace in her hand and pulled it from her neck. Over her cry of shock, she felt herself grow stronger, like her stolen magic was glad to be back where it belonged.

She ran to Bow and knelt beside him.

"Bow, take my hand!" She cried. Bow complied, doubling over in pain as he did.

*Please work, please work, please work…*she begged silently, clinging to Bow's hand.

A split second later, she and Bow were laying in the grass in front of a house-

The house had an apple tree in front of the door.

"Oh," Bow breathed, recognizing the house. "This is-"

"What on- Bow!"

Both Bow and Glimmer turned their heads to see two gentlemen- two men that looked like Bow- running out of the house.

"Dads," Bow said, propping himself up on his elbow. "I think my girlfriend might be the lost princess."

Chapter End Notes

hi friends! maybe I updated two nights in a row and what about it?

rehearsal REALLY took it out of me tonight (breaking in brand new character shoes on an outdoor stage is not very fun), so getting to come back home and write more for all of you was truly a blessing.

anyway, we are in the home stretch! please leave kudos and comments if you feel so moved, and as always, thank you thank you thank you thank you thank you for reading.

all my love,
Somebody's Muse

Happily Ever After

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow's blood was on Glimmer's hands in every sense of the phrase. But in a far more literal sense, it was staining the grass of the Whispering Woods, as well.

"Let me try again," Glimmer said, knowing that she was in a race against time. Her Bow, her sweet archer, was moments away from his earthly demise. He looked up at her, his hand still clutching his abdomen.

"Glimmer, I…"

"Don't try to talk," She said. "Not right now, just let me…"

She took his hand again and tried to picture his childhood home, tried to teleport them somewhere- anywhere, where someone could help him. He was losing so much blood, his face was so pale…

But they stayed there, fixed on one spot in the middle of the Whispering Woods, far from her tower, far from Bright Moon, far from anyone in the world who could save her beloved's life.

Bow's grip on her hand started to loosen.

"No, Bow, please, hang on to me, please hang on…" She pleaded. "Please, just for a little while longer, I'll find a way, I just need a little more time…"

Bow's beautiful eyes closed and he let go of her hand, it fell on top of his bleeding chest.

"Bow?" Glimmer placed her hand beneath his jawline- no pulse greeted her. "No! No, Bow, please! Bow, I'm so sorry, I'm so sorry, please come back!"

She had failed- her mother had been right, she wasn't strong enough to teleport them both, she didn't have enough magic, she wasn't enough.

And Bow was gone because of her.

Glimmer's eyes opened and she jolted upwards, her hand flying over her racing heart. It only took a few seconds for her ears to stop ringing, and a few more for her to remember where she was.

In the darkness, she could make out the many sights of Bow's childhood bedroom- his dresser, a bookshelf, pictures of his siblings…

Beside her, Bow shifted in his sleep. She breathed a sigh of relief.

It was only a dream, she told herself. *He's still here.*

By some miracle, she had teleported them back to his parents' house where his dads, who were every bit as sweet as he was, had patched him up and cried with her and stayed at his bedside with her. They said that if they had shown up any later, Bow might not have survived. The mere thought was enough to make Glimmer want to weep all over again.

The whole lost princess thing had taken longer to explain, especially since Glimmer was still wrapping her head around it. In the end, they had all agreed- Glimmer and Bow would both venture to Bright Moon after Bow had had a chance to rest and recover, but not a moment later.

And from there…

"Glimmer? Honey?"

Bow's voice pulled her out of her thoughts. He knew that she was having nightmares- the first night out of her tower, she had tried sleeping in his dads' guest room. The arrangement hadn't even lasted six hours- Bow had heard her crying through the wall and was there to calm her down, to hold her and assure her that she

was alright, that he was alive and beside her, and that he wasn't going anywhere. The next night, she fell asleep in his arms and woke up the same way.

His presence hadn't keep her dreams at bay, but it was easier to feel calmer when she listened to the steadiness of his breath and still-beating heart or felt the way his chest moved when he sang her back to sleep.

"Hey," He said softly, gently tugging on her shirtsleeve. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing," She said. "Go back to sleep."

"Not nothing," He insisted. "Come on, lay back down."

She complied, laying on her side so she could face him.

"I'm sorry I woke you up," She said.

"Was it the same dream?"

She nodded her head, her hand gripping the front of her shirt (which was actually one of Bow's shirts, she insisted that they were softer than her own) at the neckline, where her necklace

used to fall. Sometimes he caught her reaching for it, forgetting that it was gone.

For the most part, each of her nightmares featured the same things: she and Bow were somewhere in the Whispering Woods, and she couldn't teleport them somewhere safe. Sometimes she couldn't teleport at all, sometimes she was only a few feet away from his home's door but still too late. Sometimes her kidnapper was standing over her, telling her over and over again that it was her fault that he was gone, that if she had just listened, he would still be alive, that his life would have been a thousand times better without her presence. One way or another, her attempts to save her love's life, the life he had given to protect her, were too little, too late. *She* was too little, too late.

There had only been one exception, one variation on the theme- one night, she dreamt that she woke up in her tower, all alone all over again. She went about her day as usual, Bow's arrows nowhere to be found. She only made one cup of tea. It was like they had never met at all, and never would. When she had woken up, she wept harder and longer than Bow would have thought possible. When she finally calmed down enough to tell him what had happened, he had held her even tighter and cried with her, his tears soaking her soft, pink curls. The mere idea of Glimmer spending her life alone, far away from the truth and even farther away from him, was enough to break his heart.

“Come here,” he said, beckoning her towards him so she could lay in his arms. She moved closer to him, but didn’t raise her eyes to meet his.

“Do you think she’s still alive?” She asked.

“Without her magic, her chances are pretty slim.” He answered, carding his fingers through her hair.

“If she’s still alive, do you think she’s going to try and find me?”

Bow’s hands stopped stroking her head, and he was silent for a moment

“I don’t know, baby.” He finally replied.

“She tried to…” She gently traced the scar on his chest. “She almost…”

“But she didn’t,” He said. “You got me back home, and that’s what matters.”

“I won’t let her hurt you again,” Glimmer said fiercely, her magenta brows forming a hard line over her downcast eyes. “If she ever finds us, I won’t let her touch you.”

“I know,” He said. “I trust you.”

His hand moved from her hair to her cheek, her brow relaxed as she leaned against his touch.

“I’m really, really glad you found my tower, Bow.” She said softly, putting her hand over his.

He pulled her closer to him and kissed her forehead. Glimmer’s forehead and cheeks had been kissed more in the last two days than in her entire life, to say nothing of the times she had been hugged, or that her hands had been held.

“I am too,” He said. “You’re my favorite thing that has ever happened to me.”

“You almost died because of me,” She said.

“Hey, remember what we said? That wasn’t your fault-“

“And there’s no use feeling guilty,” She finished for him.

“Baby, without you-“ He furrowed his brow, searching for words. “Without you, I wouldn’t have been brave enough to tell my dads I wanted to join the Rebellion, I would have still been wandering around the Whispering Woods, trying to figure out where I belonged. You found me, too.”

Glimmer smiled and pressed a soft kiss to his lips. Bow loved when she kissed him first.

“Try to go back to sleep, alright?” He said. “I’ll be right here.”

Glimmer nuzzled against his chest and closed her eyes.

“That’s my girl,” He said, kissing the top of her head. “Goodnight, sweetheart.”

“Goodnight, Bow.”

oOo

Glimmer’s hands weren’t shaking because they were holding onto Bow’s. They stood on the balcony of Queen Angella’s palace, waiting to meet her. Glimmer was wondering how the palace guard who had greeted them was faring in her explanation, how could you tell your queen that her long lost daughter had all of a sudden shown up?

“You’re sure I look alright?” She asked, taking another glance down at her dress. “Am I overdressed?”

“You look beautiful, sweetheart,” He said. "She's going to-"

The palace doors opened, and Queen Angella stepped onto the balcony.

As soon as Glimmer laid eyes on her, she knew.

And as soon as the queen laid eyes on her, she knew.

They were silent as they collapsed into each other's arms, crying tears of joy and holding each other like they were never going to let go.

"My love," Angella said softly, her voice thick with tears.

"Mom," Glimmer said back. She was *hugging her mom*.

"You're so grown up," Angella told her. "And so beautiful. Oh, you look like your father…"

Glimmer smiled.

"Who do I have to thank for bringing you home?" Angella asked after a long moment.

Glimmer wiped her cheek on her sleeve and stood, reaching out towards Bow. He took her hand again.

“This is Bow,” She said. “He’s- well, he’s everything.”

“Your majesty,” Bow said, bowing his head.

“None of that,” Angella said, putting her hand that wasn’t holding Glimmer’s on his shoulder. “I will always be in your debt, my dear boy.”

“It was my pleasure,” Bow said, squeezing Glimmer’s hand. Angella’s smile grew.

“Now, the two of you do have some explaining to do,” She said. “I would love to hear your story- and then, I think a celebration is in order.”

oOo

The people of Bright Moon rejoiced at the return of their lost princess, and they threw a party that put Glimmer’s birthday to shame in every way. In 24 hours, Glimmer had talked to and danced with and met more people than she ever could have imagined, and Bow watched her with nothing but pride and love in his heart. Glimmer would be the perfect princess for her people, and they would love her as much as she loved them.

When night fell on the second day of their celebration, Glimmer left Bow’s sight for the first time since their last time in her tower.

He glanced around the square, scanning the crowd for a familiar flash of pink, but she was nowhere to be found.

Then he glanced up at the palace's balcony. He smiled and made his way to the palace.

Glimmer's back was facing him when he reached the balcony, the same place where she and the Queen reunited the previous day. Bow took her hand and pressed it against his lips, properly greeting his princess.

"Princess," He said. "I've been looking everywhere for you."

Glimmer turned to him and smiled. "I didn't mean to leave you- I just…" She glanced back down to the village. "I didn't want to forget any of this. I want to remember just how happy everyone is."

"Are you happy?" Bow asked.

"I am," She said.

But her brow stayed furrowed.

“You’re making your thinking face,” He told her. “Honey, is something wrong?”

Glimmer turned towards him. He took both of her hands in his.

“The woman and her gardener,” She said thoughtfully after a moment. “They lived happily ever after, of course, but what happened when the sun rose? They continued to love one another, but…”

“But what, sweetheart?” Bow gently prompted.

“This is the happiest I’ve ever been,” She said. “I finally got to meet my mom, I finally know who I am and where my real home was this whole time- but none of that makes me happier than you do, Bow.”

Bow nodded his head and took a step closer towards her.

“But eventually, the celebration is going to end. The sun is going to rise, and you’re going to fight in the Rebellion,” She said. “You’re going to take on the Horde directly. You’re going to do what you’ve always wanted.”

Bow nodded his head.

“Which could be very dangerous for you,” Glimmer went on.

“I know,” Bow said, squeezing her hands.

“I do too,” Glimmer said. “That’s why I’m coming with you.”

“You- what?”

“I’ve spent the last eighteen years staring at the world from afar,” She said. “And I won’t do it any longer, not if I can help it. If you’re going to put your life in danger for my people, then I’m going to, too. And someone has to look after you, my Bow,” She said. “Someone has to keep you safe.”

“Are you sure?” He asked.

“I am,” She said. “I’ve thought about it, and I’ve already talked to Mom. Fighting is in my blood, after all.”

Bow smiled. “I can’t argue with that.”

“So we agree,” She said, looping her arms around his neck. “Where you go, I go.”

“Where you go, I go,” He agreed, tightening his arms around her waist. “My brave, beautiful girl. My only love.”

Glimmer stood on her tiptoes so she could kiss him, knowing that even though she was going to be exposed to more danger than she ever had before, she and Bow would always have one another. She would look after him.

And she knew that he would look after her. After all, he had promised her so.

The princess and the archer held one another tightly, basking in the glory of their happy ending, feeling all the happier because it was a happy beginning, as well.

Chapter End Notes

Well.

I cannot thank all of you enough for going on this journey with me- your kind words and kudos mean more to me than you will ever know. I will carry them in my heart always.

It was an absolute joy to get to write this story for all of you- with all of the stress and ~emotional turmoil~ that take place during day-to-day existence, getting to sit down and write a fairytale was such a comfort. And as ridiculous as it sounds, the kindness that Moon Song was met with kind of restored my faith in happy endings.

And like, like sweet Bow and Glimmer's, this is a happy beginning! I already have 3,000 words of my next work written! This is only the start, dear ones.

As always, please leave kudos and comments if you feel so moved.

Thank you, thank you, thank you.

All my love,
Somebody's Muse

End Notes

Hi friends! My roommate made me watch SPOP and now I am hyper-fixating. Thanks a million for reading, please leave kudos or comments if you feel so moved. Also, the title is inspired by "Moon Song" by Phoebe Bridgers, which is fully not indicative of Bow and Glimmer's relationship, but is very beautiful and was my anthem throughout this past week (which also happened to be finals week. At long last, my Hot Girl Summer can begin). I am available on Tumblr @somebodys-muse and would be happy to take suggestions for future chapters. I love you all very much.
XOXO,
Somebody's Muse

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!